and *irbidistan* (Zoroastrian priestly institution) near Kuh-i Khwaja, now in modern Iran's Sistan and Baluchistan Province. The construction method of stone foundations supporting sun-dried brick walls, widespread throughout pre-Islamic Afghanistan, was prevalent here as well (Ghanimati 2000: 144). Given the difficulty of pinpointing dates within the span of the Sasanian centuries – particularly in heavily trafficked landscapes such as the historically well-traversed Sistan – it is unfortunate that the site's sample collections were not more thoroughly published (fieldwork was conducted separately by A. Stein and E. Herzfeld in the early twentieth century; for the Herzfeld reproductions see Kröger 1982: pls. 23/6 [painting], 103/1–2, 104/4 [stucco]). Further sampling and ^{14}C analysis in the 1990s resulted in the discernment of two or three construction phases for the complex, ranging from the late Parthian through late Sasanian periods (second–seventh centuries). Cf. Ghanimati 2000; Canepa 2013. However, Kröger (2005) dated the site to the "early Sasanian period" or *c.* third–fourth centuries CE. For the other sites, see Schmidt 1937: 337–338; also Kimball 1937: 347–350, fig. 173, pls. LXXIV–LXXV; Kröger 1982: pls. 88, 1–7 and 89, 1–7; Kröger (2005); Boucharlat 2019: 362–363.

54. Even with important discoveries during the intervening decades, Kröger's 1982 monograph still serves as the main reference for Sasanian stucco finds from across the empire, representing a transregional study of the medium throughout the Sasanian lands. See also Kröger 2005; Boucharlat 2019: 351.
55. It should be noted that Kröger (2005) posited stylistic and iconographic echoes of late Sasanian stucco from sites such as Nizamabad and Tepe Mil in that of early Islamic palace complexes (e.g., Khirbat al-Mafjar, late seventh–early eighth centuries CE). Characterizing the process as one of "both a continuity and a change" initiated by the work of "northern Persian" artisans working in Palestine, it forms a possible parallel to the processes unfolding in the eastern reaches of the Sasanian realms during the seventh–tenth centuries as noted here.
56. Cf. Bosworth 1994: 9ff.
57. Marquart, relying on observations gleaned from al-Biruni (cited in Bosworth 1961: 124), considered the usual root of RTBL in Arabic sources as erroneous, arguing instead for "Zunbil" as a title (not a personal name) of a ruling lineage with lingering Hephthalite or Western Turk origins. The repeated occurrence of the term in *Tarikh-i Sistan* ((trans. Gold) 1976: esp. 74 n. 1, 170) hints at a localized nomenclature. But most scholars now favor the RTBL root over Marquart's reading, as the likely Arabicization of the Turkic title *iltäbär*: see Bosworth 1968a: 34–36; Bosworth 2008: 97–99, 106–109; Ball 1988: 134–135; Ball 1996: 399; Inaba 2010; Gardizi (trans. Bosworth) 2011: 128, n. 18; Rezakhani 2017: 165ff; N. Sims-Williams (cited by W. Ball, pers. comm., April 2020); Ball 2020. Notwithstanding the etymological arguments above, al-Biruni's characterization of Zamindawar's famed shrine of Zun/Zhun as dedicated to a minor sun deity can be circumstantially confirmed. Zamindawar lay on well-trodden commercial routes linking Panjab (and ultimately the subcontinent) with the greater Iranian world. Multan in southern Panjab was not only a significant commercial node but also home to the